The Emancipation Proclamation & the Gettysburg Address

President Abraham Lincoln · January 1, 1863 & November 19, 1863

Source: Emancipation Proclamation (U.S. National Archives, Milestone Documents) and Gettysburg Address, Bliss copy (Avalon Project, Yale Law School). Public domain.

The Emancipation Proclamation (Jan. 1, 1863) used Lincoln's war powers to declare enslaved people in Confederate-held territory 'forever free' and to authorize Black enlistment in the Union Army. The Gettysburg Address (Nov. 19, 1863), delivered at the dedication of the battlefield cemetery, reframed the war as a struggle to make the Declaration of Independence's promise of equality real. Read together, the two documents mark Lincoln's redefinition of the war's purpose.

Connect: The Gettysburg Address invokes 'all men are created equal.' How is Lincoln in 1863 using the Declaration (Class 3) to redefine what the war is about?

Key Passages

Emancipation — a war measure, with exceptions

by virtue of the power in me vested as Commander-in-Chief, of the Army and Navy of the United States in time of actual armed rebellion against the authority and government of the United States, and as a fit and necessary war measure for suppressing said rebellion … which excepted parts, are for the present, left precisely as if this proclamation were not issued.

Emancipation — freedom and Black enlistment

I do order and declare that all persons held as slaves within said designated States, and parts of States, are, and henceforward shall be free; and that the Executive government of the United States, including the military and naval authorities thereof, will recognize and maintain the freedom of said persons. … such persons of suitable condition, will be received into the armed service of the United States

Gettysburg Address — opening

Fourscore and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent a new nation, conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Gettysburg Address — closing

It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us … that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain, that this nation under God shall have a new birth of freedom, and that government of the people, by the people, for the people shall not perish from the earth.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Civil War in its third year: Union victory at Antietam (1862) allowed the Proclamation; Gettysburg (July 1863) was the bloodiest battle of the war.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Proclamation: Confederate states, the Union army, enslaved people, and foreign powers such as Britain. Gettysburg: the crowd at the cemetery and the Northern public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Lincoln as commander in chief, using war powers and seeking to give meaning to the war; enslaved people's own role in seeking freedom is not described.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Specific Evidence (1 pt): Use TWO specific pieces of evidence from these documents to argue that the war's purpose changed between 1861 and 1863.
2. What did the Emancipation Proclamation NOT do — and why is that important?
3. How does the Gettysburg Address reframe the founding documents?

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> Two turning points of 1863: the Proclamation reframed the war as a fight to end slavery and opened the army to Black soldiers, while at Gettysburg Lincoln redefined the war as a test of whether a nation "dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal" could endure.

The Emancipation Proclamation — January 1, 1863

The preliminary proclamation of September 22, 1862, as quoted

Whereas, on the twenty-second day of September, in the year of our Lord one thousand eight hundred and sixty-two, a proclamation was issued by the President of the United States, containing, among other things, the following, to wit: "That on the first day of January, in the year of our Lord one thousand eight hundred and sixty-three, all persons held as slaves within any State or designated part of a State, the people whereof shall then be in rebellion against the United States, shall be then, thenceforward, and forever free; and the Executive Government of the United States, including the military and naval authority thereof, will recognize and maintain the freedom of such persons, and will do no act or acts to repress such persons, or any of them, in any efforts they may make for their actual freedom.

[. . .]

The war-power justification and the designated states

Now, therefore I, Abraham Lincoln, President of the United States, by virtue of the power in me vested as Commander-in-Chief, of the Army and Navy of the United States in time of actual armed rebellion against the authority and government of the United States, and as a fit and necessary war measure for suppressing said rebellion, do, on this first day of January, in the year of our Lord one thousand eight hundred and sixty-three, and in accordance with my purpose so to do publicly proclaimed for the full period of one hundred days, from the day first above mentioned, order and designate as the States and parts of States wherein the people thereof respectively, are this day in rebellion against the United States, the following, to wit: Arkansas, Texas, Louisiana, (except the Parishes of St. Bernard, Plaquemines, Jefferson, St. John, St. Charles, St. James Ascension, Assumption, Terrebonne, Lafourche, St. Mary, St. Martin, and Orleans, including the City of New Orleans) Mississippi, Alabama, Florida, Georgia, South Carolina, North Carolina, and Virginia, (except the forty-eight counties designated as West Virginia, and also the counties of Berkley, Accomac, Northampton, Elizabeth City, York, Princess Ann, and Norfolk, including the cities of Norfolk and Portsmouth[)], and which excepted parts, are for the present, left precisely as if this proclamation were not issued.

The declaration of freedom and Black enlistment

And by virtue of the power, and for the purpose aforesaid, I do order and declare that all persons held as slaves within said designated States, and parts of States, are, and henceforward shall be free; and that the Executive government of the United States, including the military and naval authorities thereof, will recognize and maintain the freedom of said persons. And I hereby enjoin upon the people so declared to be free to abstain from all violence, unless in necessary self-defence; and I recommend to them that, in all cases when allowed, they labor faithfully for reasonable wages. And I further declare and make known, that such persons of suitable condition, will be received into the armed service of the United States to garrison forts, positions, stations, and other places, and to man vessels of all sorts in said service. And upon this act, sincerely believed to be an act of justice, warranted by the Constitution, upon military necessity, I invoke the considerate judgment of mankind, and the gracious favor of Almighty God.

The Gettysburg Address — November 19, 1863

The Gettysburg Address (whole)

“Fourscore and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent a new nation, conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal. Now we are engaged in a great civil war, testing whether that nation or any nation so conceived and so dedicated can long endure. We are met on a great battlefield of that war. We have come to dedicate a portion of that field as a final resting-place for those who here gave their lives that that nation might live. It is altogether fitting and proper that we should do this. But in a larger sense, we cannot dedicate, we cannot consecrate, we cannot hallow this ground. The brave men, living and dead who struggled here have consecrated it far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here. It is for us the living rather to be dedicated here to the unfinished work which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced. It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us—that from these honored dead we take increased devotion to that cause for which they gave the last full measure of devotion—that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain, that this nation under God shall have a new birth of freedom, and that government of the people, by the people, for the people shall not perish from the earth.”

Words to know

Whereas — legal word meaning ‘because of the fact that’

thenceforward — from that time onward

repress — hold down by force

war measure — an action justified by the president’s wartime powers

garrison — station troops to guard a place

Fourscore — four times twenty, so eighty

consecrate — make holy

hallow — make holy; honor as sacred